

Birds of prey get their freedom

3 Northern Harriers are released back into the wild

By LEAH KOHLENBERG

Staff Writer

SUNSET BEACH — The boxes Barbara Schmidt's husband, Walter, brought reverently down to the couple's back yard Sunday afternoon looked like they could have been delivered by the mail carrier.

But these were no ordinary packages.

When Mrs. Schmidt cut open the sealing tape and flipped back the lid, the boxes' contents — three young Northern Harriers, or Marsh Hawks — blinked unsteadily a few times before soaring into the air along the Intracoastal Waterway.

The three birds were taken to the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte in June. The center cares for raptors — birds of prey — that have been orphaned, injured, abandoned or carelessly picked up by humans. If possible, the birds are set free once more in the wild; others are kept at the center.

Mrs. Schmidt, a center volunteer who splits her time between Sunset Beach and Huntersville, picked up the birds Sunday morning and drove them to the beach to set them free.

"They were so quiet on the way down, I thought 'Oh my, I hope they are all right,'" Mrs. Schmidt said.

The three birds — two males and one female — were found as babies in Trigg County, Ky., in June. Apparently, some people saw the baby birds and, think-

ing they had been abandoned, picked them up to "rescue" them, said Laura Keistler, development director at the Raptor Center.

"I guess the kind of sad things about it is the people who found the birds thought they were doing a good thing . . . but really they did more damage than good," Ms. Keistler said.

Although there are no recorded Marsh Hawk populations in North Carolina, the state is one of their stops on the birds' yearly migration to warmer temperatures. Mrs. Schmidt hopes the birds will winter in the Carolinas and then pick up with a flock of hawks migrating back up North next summer.

With their wizened faces and long, thin bodies, the birds look like a cross between an owl and a hawk. They live in fields and marshes, and prey upon small rodents, birds, insects and amphibians.

The center banded the birds so they can be tracked; research is a sideline at the raptor center.

Mrs. Schmidt sits on the deck of her home, where — coincidentally — the casual viewer can see Bird Island in the distance. She says she has a fascination with the birds of prey that she now works to save.

"I was always interested in birds," Mrs. Schmidt said. "But raptors are something far different from ordinary birds."

Staff Writer Tracy Rose contributed to this report.



Staff photo / TODD SUMLIN

Barbara Schmidt releases the last of three Northern Harriers at her Sunset Beach home Sunday afternoon.